which in spite of everything has abounding vitality and spreads abroad,' he said. 'We tend to overwhelm others both by virtue of our numbers, and sometimes by virtue of the economic position we might develop there. That naturally frightens others who may not have that vitality in them and they want to protect themselves against it.'[38] While asserting that the Indian government wished to protect the interests of Indians abroad, the principled Nehru asserted 'we cannot protect any vested interest which injure the cause of the country they are in'.[39]

During the Constituent Assembly debates, when the issue of citizenship was discussed with respect to the Indian diaspora, Nehru remarked that only those could be offered citizenship who chose to be exclusively Indian citizens. If they chose another citizenship, he said, 'our interest in them becomes cultural and humanitarian, not political'. Nehru argued against dual citizenship for overseas Indians, telling the Constituent Assembly that it could not treat them as Indians while also demanding complete franchise for them in the countries where they lived. 'Of course, the two things do not go together,' he observed, adding, 'Either they get franchise as nationals of the other country, or you treat them as Indians minus the franchise and ask for them the most favoured treatment given to an alien.'[40]

This view resulted in India's decision to not offer the option of dual citizenship even though it is widely practised by many countries. In recent years, India has offered a lifelong visa and access to their country of origin for Indians settled abroad, giving them an identification card as an overseas Indian or a person of Indian origin (PIO) though they are not given an Indian passport and cannot vote in India though they may own property there.

Over the years the Indian diaspora has grown, especially in the Gulf, the United Kingdom and North America. The NRIs serve as a source of economic benefits to India, providing employment to a large number of Indians and making India one of the top recipients of remittances. New